UNIVERSITY OF IDAHO AI SYMPOSIUM 2026 · TRACK 4: AI ETHICS AND FUTURE

Narratives that have, and will, shape both us and the machines

A workshop with the NARC lab

Bert Baumgaertner Politics and Philosophy

Hadley Huzefka

Jason Culbertson

Chloe Luo

Thursday, October 29, 2026

BEFORE WE START

Follow along on your own screen

These slides

bertybaums.github.io/narratives-workshop

The puzzles

narc.insight.uidaho.edu

A laptop works best. Pairs are fine. A plain-text companion with everything in the slides is linked from the workshop page.

THE NEXT 75 MINUTES

The plan

1	Stories we reason with	Bert	5 min
2	How a NARC puzzle works, and how the models did	Bert	5 min
3	Three puzzles from the lab	Hadley, Jason, Chloe	21 min
4	Your turn: write a story, test it on MindRouter	Everyone	20 min
5	Stories about AI that leave us room to choose	Discussion	19 min

PART 1 · STORIES WE REASON WITH

We reason with narratives, analogies and metaphors

For short, NAMs.

PART 1 · NAMS ARE EVERYWHERE

What does each one let you predict?

RESEARCH

Predicts: like a breeder's choices, helpful traits spread over generations.

Breaks: no one is doing the selecting.

Predicts: the genes spell out the finished body.

Breaks: development depends on the environment too.

TEACHING

Predicts: electrons circle the nucleus like planets.

Breaks: electrons don't follow orbits, so it fails for chemistry.

Predicts: memories are stored, then pulled out intact.

Breaks: remembering rebuilds a memory, and can change it.

DAILY LIFE

Predicts: a jam spreads backward, like a wave in a pipe.

Breaks: drivers choose; water doesn't.

Predicts: it needs charging soon, or it stops.

Breaks: a dead phone comes back once you plug it in.

Click a card to flip it.

PART 1 · A STORY PICKS WHAT COMES NEXT

A colleague hasn't answered your email in a week

"She's swamped." | "She's annoyed with me." | "It went to spam."

What you expect next

A reply, eventually.

What you do

Wait. Maybe a gentle nudge.

Same facts. A different story picks a different next step. We built puzzles to study this, in people and in AI models.

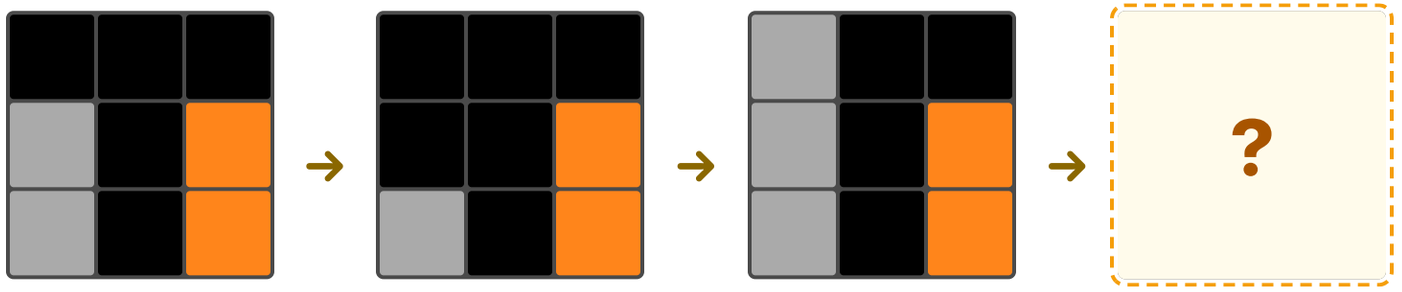
PART 2 · NARC PUZZLES

Can a story fill in what the pictures leave open?

Narrative Augmented Reasoning Challenges

PART 2 · TRY ONE

Chat: what goes in grid 4?

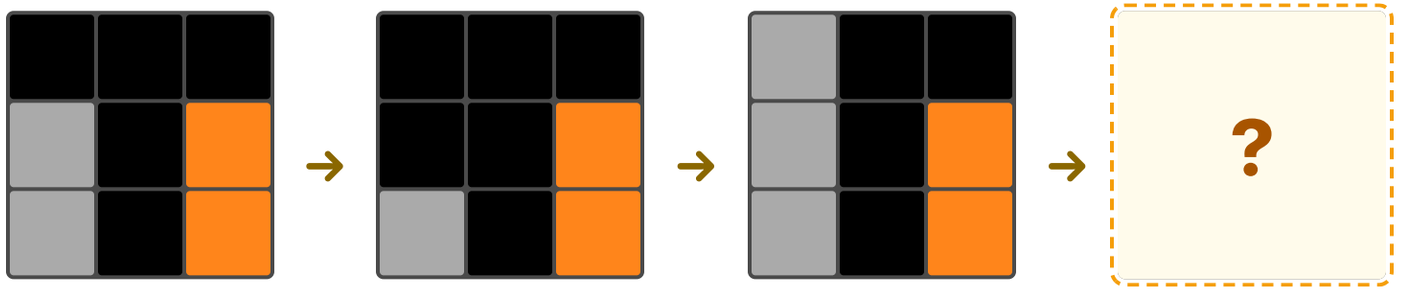




Start from grid 3 | Clear | Check

PART 2 · TRY ONE

Chat: what goes in grid 4?



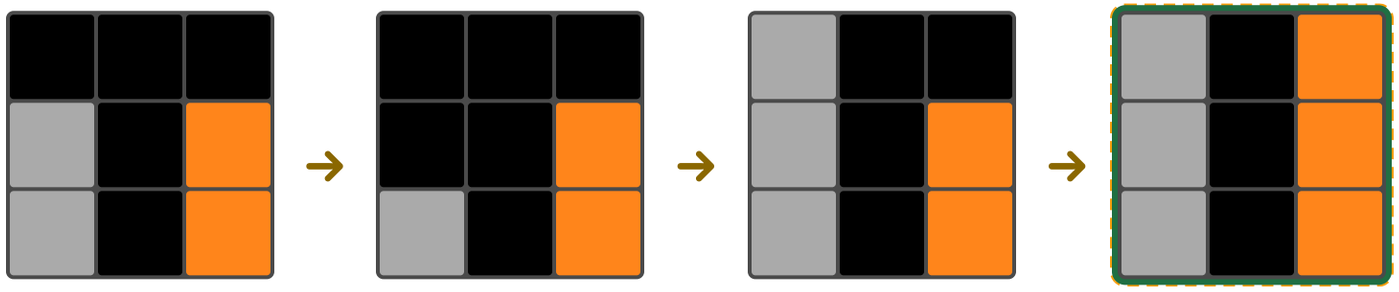
Start from grid 3 | Clear | Check

THE STORY

Ally and Bob met to chat. Ally became sad. After some encouraging words from Bob, Ally became happy. This made Bob happy too.

PART 2 · TRY ONE

Chat: what goes in grid 4?



Start from grid 3 | Clear | Check

THE STORY

Ally and Bob met to chat. Ally became sad. After some encouraging words from Bob, Ally became happy. This made Bob happy too.

PART 2 · HOW A NARC PUZZLE WORKS

Pictures, a story, and an exact answer

1. A strip of small grids

Three to eight frames that show something happening. One frame is hidden.

2. A short story

It doesn’t describe the grids. It helps only if you read it as being about the shapes.

3. Rebuild the hidden grid

Exactly, every cell the right color. Close doesn’t count.

About 320 public puzzles at narc.insight.uidaho.edu. Anyone can solve them, and anyone can make one.

PART 2 · HOW THE MODELS DID

Chat: how to read a results table

MODEL	GRIDS ONLY	STORY ONLY	GRIDS + STORY	SHUFFLED GRIDS (SOLVED OF 3)	KEY WORDS ONLY (SOLVED OF 3)
gemma-4-26b Google, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
gemma-4-31b Google, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
glm-5.3-flash RETIRED Z.ai, open weights	×	×	✓	0	1
gpt-oss-120b OpenAI, open weights	×	×	✓	0	1
gpt-oss-20b OpenAI, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
kimi-k3 Moonshot AI, open weights	×	×	✓	0	0
mimo-v2.6-flash RETIRED Xiaomi, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
nemotron-3-super NVIDIA, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
qwen3.5-122b Alibaba (Qwen), open weights	×	×	✓	0	0
qwen3.6-27b Alibaba (Qwen), open weights	×	×	×	–	–
qwen3.8-27b NARRATE Alibaba (Qwen), open weights	×	×	✓	0	1

Live results from narc.insight.uidaho.edu, October 21, 2026. One try per model per condition. The shuffled and key-word tests run three times each, only for models that solved it with grids + story.

Chat: how to read a results table

1 Each row is one AI model.

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gpt-oss-20b OpenAI, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
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PART 2 · HOW THE MODELS DID

Chat: how to read a results table

1. Each row is one AI model.
2. Three tests: the grids only, the story only, and both.

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Chat: how to read a results table

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3. Two follow-ups for models that solved it: shuffle the grids, or swap the story for its key words.

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4. Highlighted: the model you'll write for in Part 4.

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gpt-oss-20b OpenAI, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
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The NARC property: a model needs *both*. For Chat, 0 of 11 from the grids, 0 of 11 from the story, 5 of 11 with both.

PART 2 · WHAT WE MEAN BY A MODEL

Most of these models run here, on campus

A model is one trained AI system

Chatbots like ChatGPT and Claude are apps built on models. Each row in our tables is a different model.

Different makers, different sizes

Google, OpenAI, Alibaba, Moonshot AI, NVIDIA. The number in a name is roughly its size: 120b means 120 billion parameters.

Most run on MindRouter

The university's own AI service, on university-owned GPUs. Prompts and replies stay on university infrastructure. Claude Fable, the commercial one, we ran off campus for comparison.

Open to you

Sign in with your university account. Chat in the browser, or get a key to use it from your own code. Narrate uses it too.

mindrouter.uidaho.edu · Luke Sheneman's Vandal Chat session is at 2:30 today.

PART 3 · FROM THE NARC LAB

Three puzzles, three makers

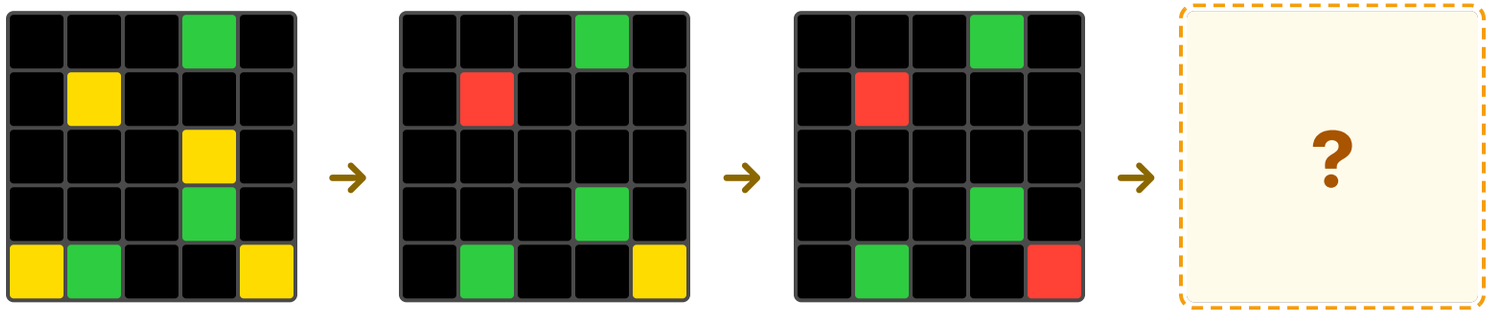
Hunt
by Hadley

The Accident
by Jason

Ballerina 4
by Chloe

PART 3 · HADLEY'S PUZZLE

Hunt: what goes in grid 4?

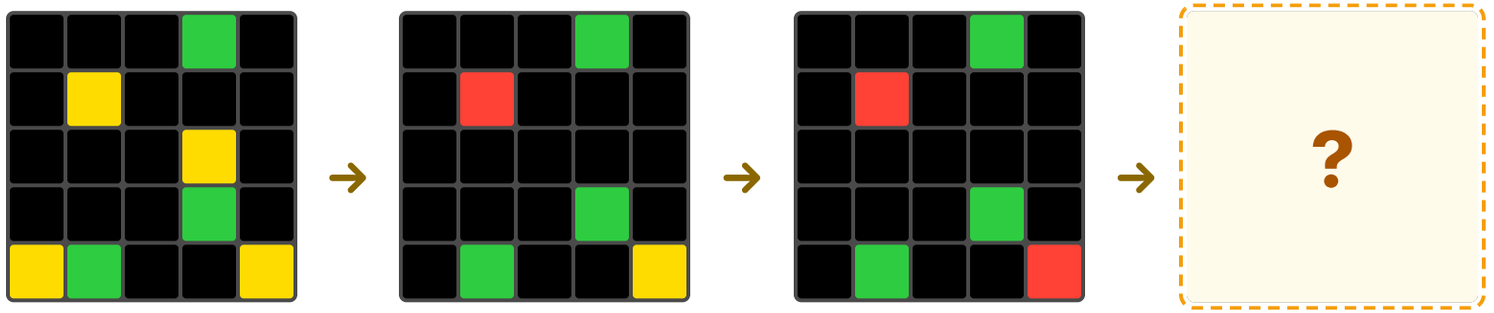




Start from grid 3 | Clear | Check

PART 3 · HADLEY'S PUZZLE

Hunt: what goes in grid 4?





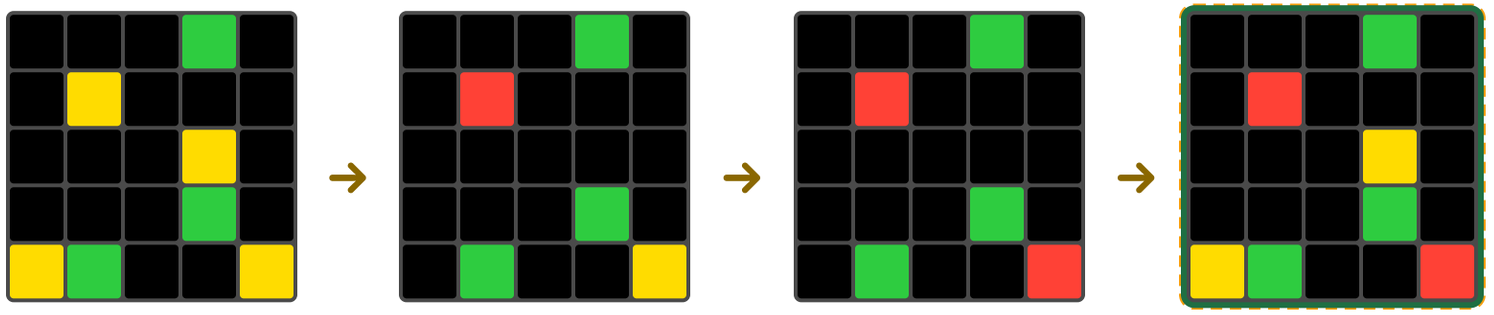
Start from grid 3 | Clear | Check

HADLEY'S STORY

Treb likes to go hunting in his free time. In the marshy area behind his house, a flock of ducks likes to hang out. The green grass can sometimes make shooting the ducks difficult, as the ducks will hide behind them. Treb was lucky enough to snipe one duck. However, the shot startled the surrounding ducks, and the ones closest to the grass hid. Treb noticed one duck still sitting out. After getting two ducks, he collects his stuff and leaves. The remaining ducks emerge from the grass to discover only bloody puddles left of their friends.

PART 3 · HADLEY'S PUZZLE

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PART 3 · HADLEY'S PUZZLE

Two ways to tell the same hunt

Identifiers for humans

- Ducks: yellow
- Grass: green
- Blood: red
- Hiding: not visible
- Emerge: visible again

Simplified story | Hadley's story

> The yellow ducks like to sit in the green grass. The hunter comes along and shoots two yellow ducks. The other two ducks hide behind the green grass. When the two yellow ducks emerge from behind the green grass, they see the red puddles left of their friends.

Same events, same answer. One version names the colors; the other leaves the reader to work them out.

PART 3 · HADLEY'S PUZZLE

Hunt: how the models did

0 of 12

grids only

0 of 12

story only

8 of 12

grids + story

Highlighted: the model Narrate uses. Tags mark the commercial model and two retired from MindRouter on October 1.

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glm-5.3-flash RETIRED Z.ai, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
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PART 3 · HADLEY'S PUZZLE

What Hadley learned

The hunter is never in the picture

Treb never appears in the grids, but he decides which ducks are there. An agent can be present in the story and absent from the scene.

Guess, then intuitive, then obvious

Without the story you guess. With it, the answer feels obvious.

Simple and complex stories both matter

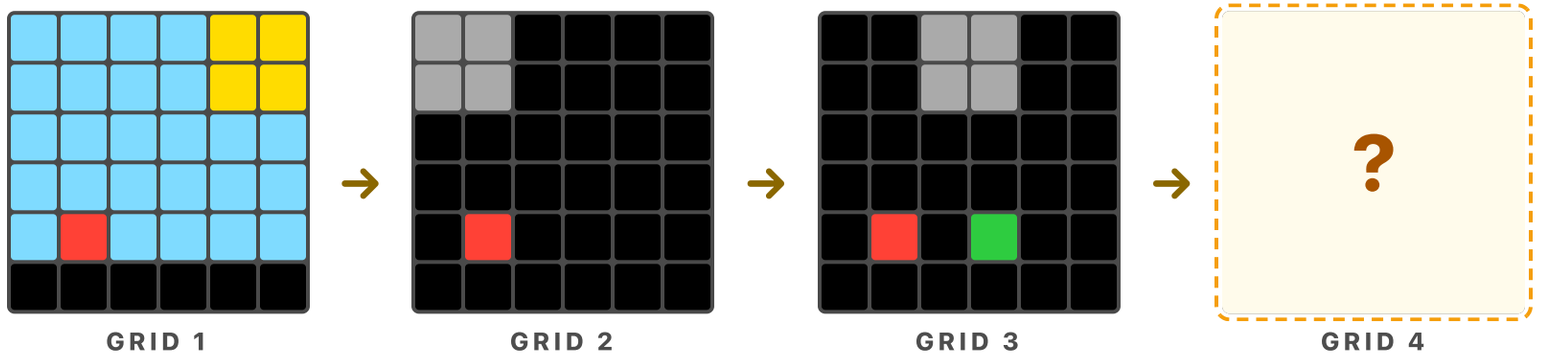
The same solution can be told in ways that look very different.

One problem, many perspectives

Different readers, one right answer. Next: one problem, many stories. That's Narrate.

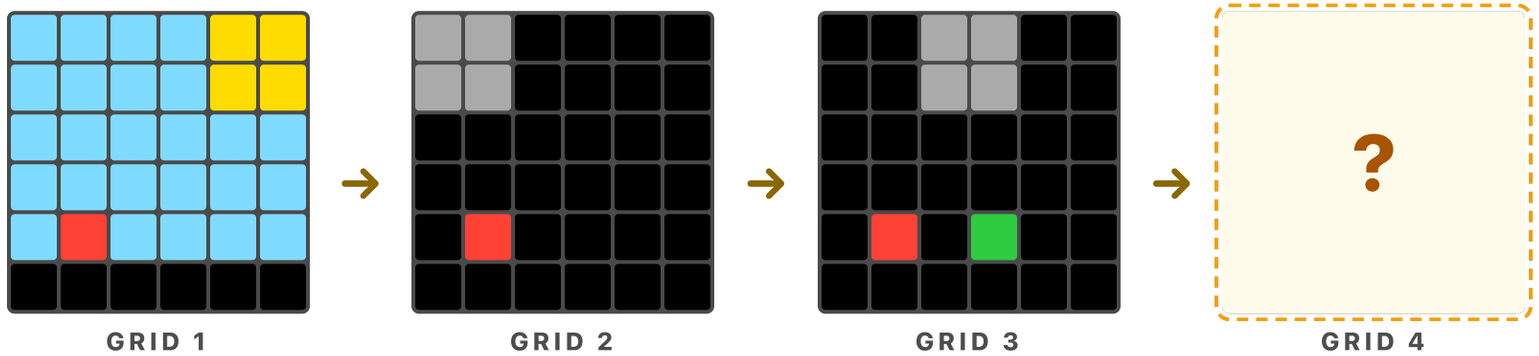
PART 3 · JASON'S PUZZLE

The Accident: what goes in grid 4?



PART 3 · JASON'S PUZZLE

The Accident: what goes in grid 4?

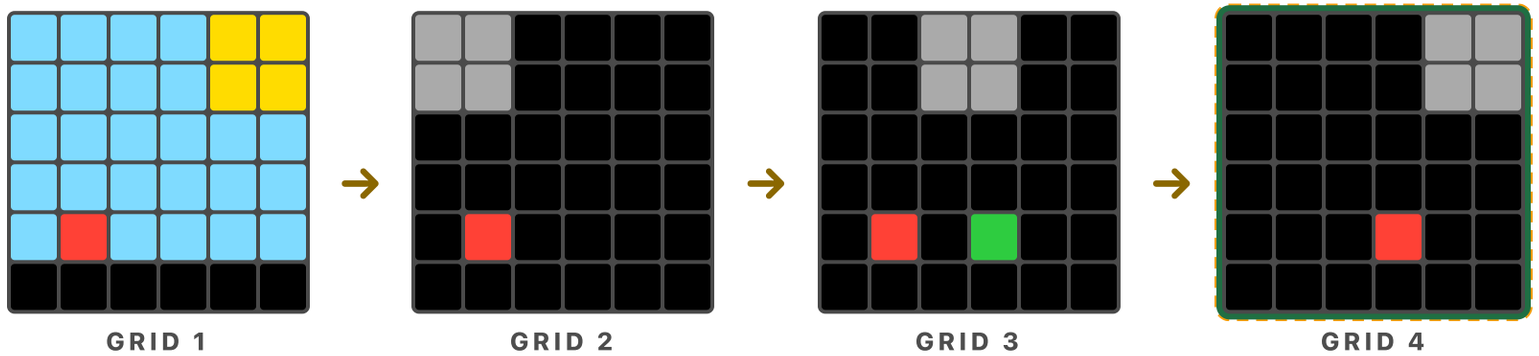


JASON'S STORY

A car stalls out on an empty highway in the middle of the desert. The driver has no cellphone service. All they can do is wait and hope that someone passes by to help. In the middle of the night, a giant tortoise approaches the vehicle. For hours, it sits and stares, wondering about the strange, still beast before it. Suddenly, the driver, who has fallen asleep at this point, feels a jolt as the car loses traction and crushes the curious tortoise.

PART 3 · JASON'S PUZZLE

The Accident: what goes in grid 4?



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PART 3 · JASON'S PUZZLE

Two ways to tell the same accident

Identifiers for humans

- Sun: yellow
- Sky: blue, then black
- Car: red
- Tortoise: green
- Moon: gray

Simplified story | Jason's story

> A red car stalls out on an empty highway. In the middle of the night, a giant green tortoise approaches the red vehicle. The driver, who has fallen asleep at this point, feels a jolt as the car loses traction and crushes the curious tortoise.

Neither version mentions the sun or the moon. The reader supplies them: night falls, and something moves across the sky, one step per frame.

PART 3 · JASON'S PUZZLE

The Accident: how the models did

0 of 12

grids only

0 of 12

story only

4 of 12

grids + story

Highlighted: the model Narrate uses. Tags mark the commercial model and two retired from MindRouter on October 1.

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glm-5.3-flash RETIRED Z.ai, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
gpt-oss-120b OpenAI, open weights	×	×	✓	0	0
gpt-oss-20b OpenAI, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
kimi-k3 Moonshot AI, open weights	×	×	✓	0	0
mimo-v2.6-flash RETIRED Xiaomi, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
nemotron-3-super NVIDIA, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
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PART 3 · JASON'S PUZZLE

What Jason learned

NUMBERS CHANGED TO MATCH THE LIVE TABLE: JASON TO CONFIRM

Easy for us still tells us a lot

A puzzle that's easy for people can still tell us a lot about AI.

A few simple pieces

The Accident only takes the car, the tortoise and the event.

The story did the work

With the story, 4 of 12 models solved it. Without it, none did.

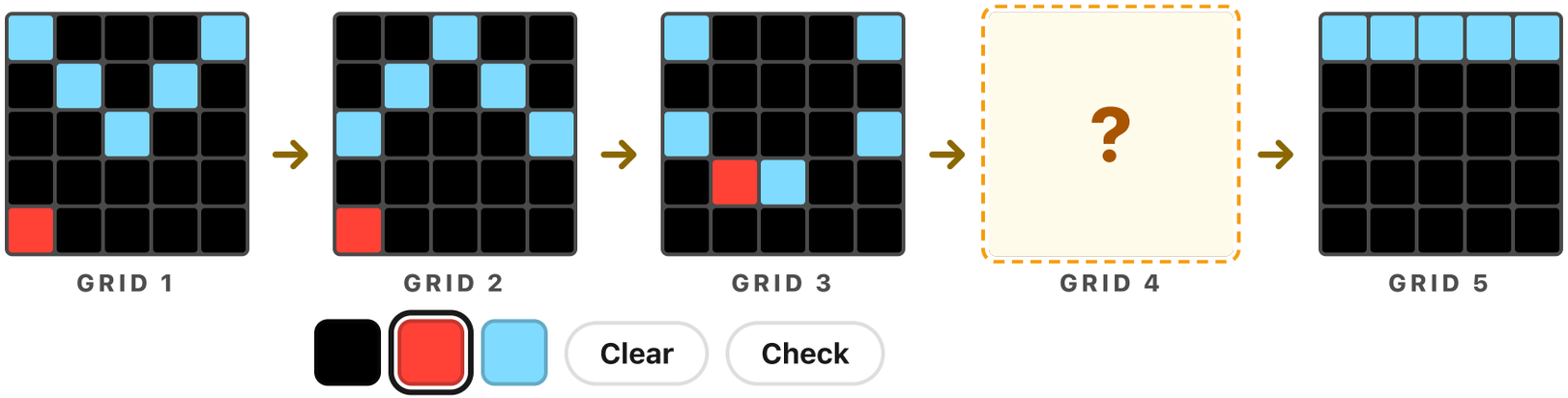
Anyone can play, make or judge

And learn how AI thinks while they do it. The puzzles invite teaching, learning and work across fields.

A bigger question: how does AI use stories to abstract and reason?

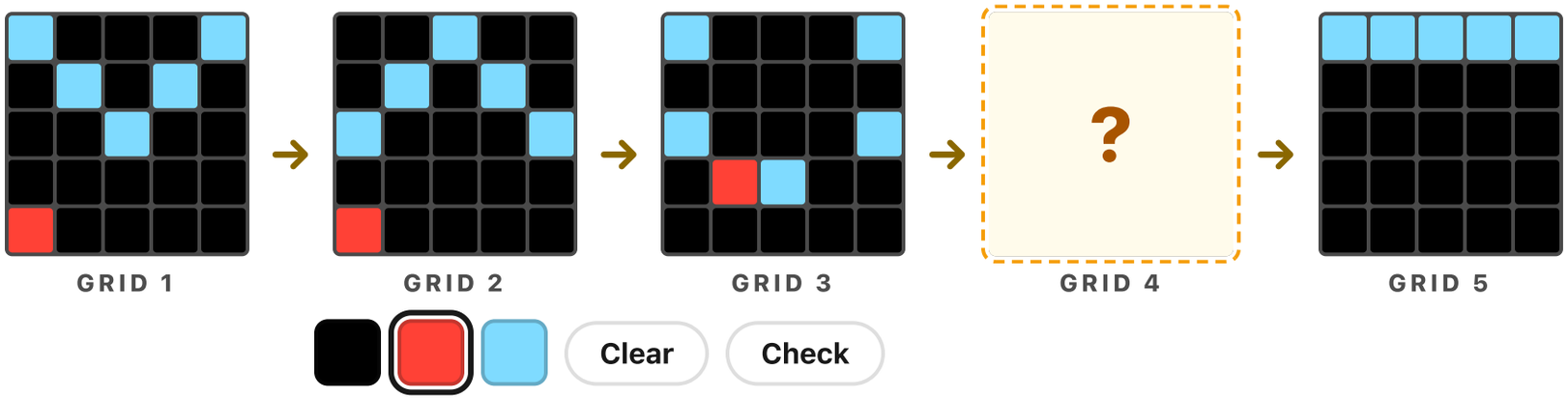
PART 3 · CHLOE'S PUZZLE

Ballerina 4: what goes in grid 4?



PART 3 · CHLOE'S PUZZLE

Ballerina 4: what goes in grid 4?

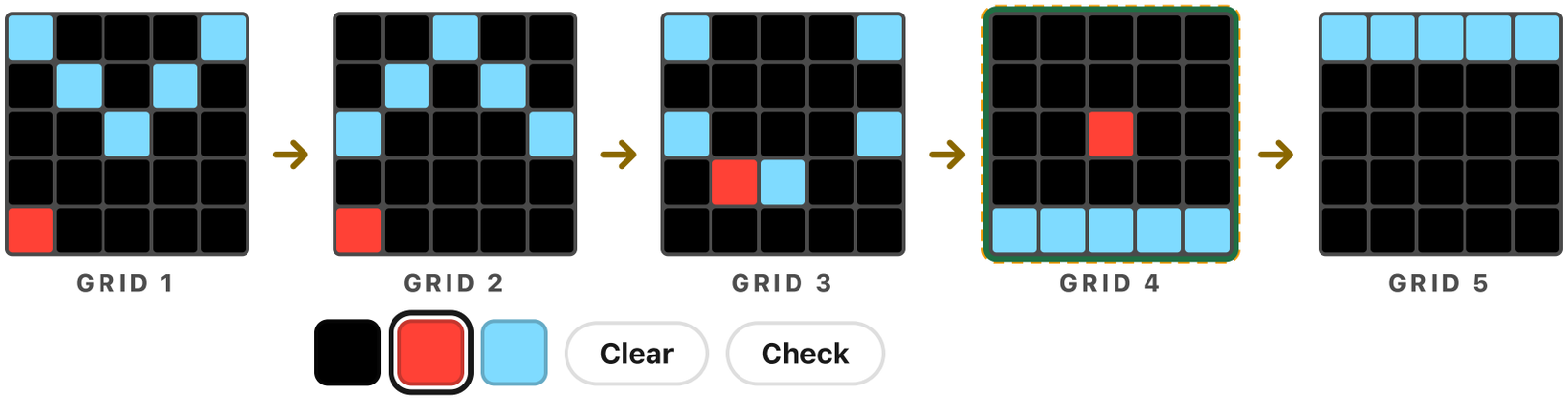


CHLOE'S STORY

A ballerina collaborated with a street dance crew for a performance. The street dance crew took the stage first, constantly changing formations and movements in sync with the music. The ballerina waited at the back of the stage for her entrance. As the music gradually slowed down, she began to join the performance. When the performance reached its climax, only the ballerina performed at the center of the stage while all the street dance crew members paused at the back of the stage. At the end of the show, the ballerina fully exited, and the street dance crew finished the performance at the very front of the stage in an unchanged formation.

PART 3 · CHLOE'S PUZZLE

Ballerina 4: what goes in grid 4?



CHLOE'S STORY

A ballerina collaborated with a street dance crew for a performance. The street dance crew took the stage first, constantly changing formations and movements in sync with the music. The ballerina waited at the back of the stage for her entrance. As the music gradually slowed down, she began to join the performance. When the performance reached its climax, only the ballerina performed at the center of the stage while all the street dance crew members paused at the back of the stage. At the end of the show, the ballerina fully exited, and the street dance crew finished the performance at the very front of the stage in an unchanged formation.

PART 3 · CHLOE'S PUZZLE

Reading Ballerina 4

DRAFT KEY: CHLOE TO CONFIRM

- Red: the ballerina
- Light blue: the street dance crew
- Top row: front of the stage
- Bottom row: back of the stage

To solve it you need both: the story, and tracking where every dancer stands from one frame to the next.

PART 3 · CHLOE'S PUZZLE

Ballerina 4: how the models did

0 of 12

grids only

0 of 12

story only

8 of 12

grids + story

Highlighted: the model Narrate uses. Tags mark the commercial model and two retired from MindRouter on October 1.

MODEL	GRIDS ONLY	STORY ONLY	GRIDS + STORY	SHUFFLED GRIDS (SOLVED OF 3)	KEY WORDS ONLY (SOLVED OF 3)
claude-fable-5-1 COMMERCIAL Anthropic, commercial, off campus	×	×	✓	not tested	not tested
gemma-4-26b Google, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
gemma-4-31b Google, open weights	×	×	✓	1	0
glm-5.3-flash RETIRED Z.ai, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
gpt-oss-120b OpenAI, open weights	×	×	✓	1	0
gpt-oss-20b OpenAI, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
kimi-k3 Moonshot AI, open weights	×	×	✓	2	0
mimo-v2.6-flash RETIRED Xiaomi, open weights	×	×	×	–	–
nemotron-3-super NVIDIA, open weights	×	×	✓	1	0
qwen3.5-122b Alibaba (Qwen), open weights	×	×	✓	1	0
qwen3.6-27b Alibaba (Qwen), open weights	×	×	✓	0	0
qwen3.8-27b NARRATE Alibaba (Qwen), open weights	×	×	✓	3	0

Live results from narc.insight.uidaho.edu, October 21, 2026. One try per model per condition. The shuffled and key-word tests run three times each, only for models that solved it with grids + story.

PART 3 · CHLOE'S PUZZLE

What Chloe learned

Two skills at once

Models have to understand the story and track positions and formations across the grids.

Different models, different results

The same puzzle split the twelve models eight to four.

Small changes matter

Hiding grids 4 and 5 together, instead of grid 4 alone, changed how the models did.

Variations are a probe

Small variations can show a model's strengths and weaknesses.

PART 3 · PUTTING THEM TOGETHER

What the three puzzles show

PUZZLE	GRIDS ONLY	STORY ONLY	GRIDS + STORY	KEY WORDS ONLY
Hunt	0 of 12	0 of 12	**8 of 12**	0 of 7 models
The Accident	0 of 12	0 of 12	**4 of 12**	0 of 3 models
Ballerina 4	0 of 12	0 of 12	**8 of 12**	0 of 7 models

The pictures alone leave the answer open. A short story settles it. And it has to be a story: a list of its key words never worked.

“Key words only” counts the models that solved it with the story, minus Claude Fable, which wasn’t tested. Each got three tries. Results as of October 21, 2026.

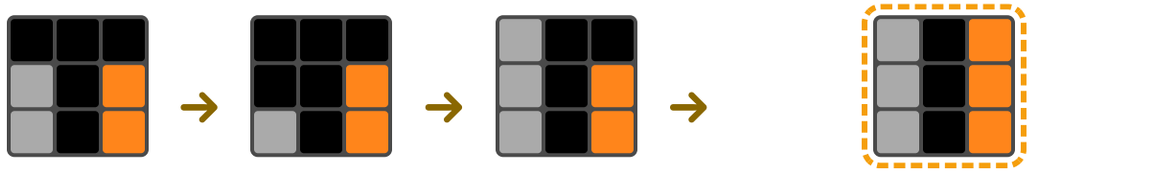
PART 4 · NARRATE

Same facts, different stories

You know what happened. Can you tell it so the model gets it right?

PART 4 · HOW NARRATE WORKS

You see the answer. The model doesn't.



1. You see every grid, including the one the model won't see.
2. You write a story about what happens. Don't spell out cells, numbers or coordinates.
3. The model gets the other grids and your story, and has to rebuild the hidden one exactly. It's **qwen3.8-27b**, on MindRouter.
4. You see whether it worked. Revise and try again.

PART 4 · YOUR TURN

Write a different story

1. Go to **narc.insight.uidaho.edu/narrate** and enter the code.
2. Pick a puzzle. Chat is the quickest.
3. Write two to five sentences. A new setting is welcome: cooking, sports, your field.
4. Submit. A test takes up to two minutes.
5. Read the result, revise, and try again.

Challenge: Narrate's model failed The Accident with Jason's story. Can yours get it there?

Invite code

AISYMP2026

Valid through November 30, 2026

12:00

Start | +1 min | Reset

Narrate is a research study for adults 18 or older, and it's voluntary. We don't ask for your name or email. Stories may be published without your name, so leave personal information out.

PART 4 · WHILE YOU WAIT

If the model is busy or the site is down

Busy

Everyone pressed Submit at once. Wait a minute and press it again. Meanwhile, write a second version.

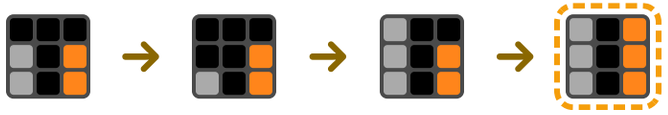
Down, or no laptop

Write your story on a card. Bert will read a few aloud and test them from the front.

Write a version that would work for a person. Then write one you think would work for the model. Are they the same?

BACKUP · SAME GRIDS, SIX RETELLINGS

Which stories work?



COOKING

Two loaves of dough were rising on the counter. The first one sank when a cold draft came through the window. The second loaf, still warm, was pushed up against it, and the first puffed up higher than before. Then the second loaf rose too.

Click to reveal

SAILING

Two boats rode the same gentle swell. The first dipped into a trough. A wave rolling off the second boat's bow lifted it higher than before. Then the second boat rose on the wave too.

Click to reveal

FIREFLIES

Two fireflies glowed softly side by side. The first one dimmed as the night cooled. Its neighbour flashed close beside it, and the first one brightened, glowing stronger than before. Seeing that, the neighbour brightened too.

Click to reveal

THEATER

Two actors waited calmly in the wings. The first one's nerves sank him into dread. His scene partner whispered a joke, and he walked on stage beaming, bolder than before. His confidence made his partner beam too.

Click to reveal

GARDENING

Two sunflowers grew side by side. The first drooped during a dry spell. The second one's deep roots shared their water, and the first stood up taller than before. Then the second grew taller too.

Click to reveal

ASTRONOMY

Two stars shone with equal light. The first faded behind a passing cloud of dust. Its companion's pull swept the dust away, and it blazed brighter than before. Then the companion flared up too.

Click to reveal

Reveal all

Pilot test, October 2026. Retellings written with an AI assistant. Results for one open model, gpt-oss-120b, two tries each. The other two models tested solved all six.

BACKUP · SAME GRIDS, DIFFERENT ENDING

Change the last sentence

“This made Bob happy too.” | “Bob stayed just as he was.” | “Then Bob had to leave.”



GRID 4 DRAWN

The original story. Bob rises. This is what happened in the puzzle.

The model followed the story it was given. Only someone who knows what happened can tell which story is true.

PART 4 · DEBRIEF

How did it go?

Count hands, then click the matching button. Shift-click removes one.

Solved on the first try	Solved after revising	Not yet	Didn’t get to submit
0	0	0	0

Reset

Read us one

A story that worked, and one that didn’t.

What did you change?

Between your first try and your last.

PART 5 · STORIES ABOUT AI

Which stories about AI should we tell?

Ones that leave us room to choose.

PART 5 · A STORY PICKS WHAT COMES NEXT

A new AI tool arrives in your department

“It’s a wave.” | “It’s an arms race.” | “It’s a forklift.”

What you expect next

It arrives whatever we do.

What you do

Adapt fast, or fall behind.

Who decides

No one. It’s weather.

Same news. The first two stories leave us nothing to decide. The third hands the decision back.

PART 5 · TWO STORIES FROM THE SUMMER AI BOOTCAMP

The gym and the treadmill

Nobody brings a forklift to the gym

The weight is the point. Some friction is the reps, the part that builds the skill. Some is the commute. Hand off the commute. Keep the reps.

The productivity treadmill

AI saves an hour, and the hour fills with more output. We run faster and stay in the same place.

Add a plate on purpose

Try it before you ask. Have the AI quiz you instead of answer you. Check one claim against the source.

Both stories ask the same two questions. Which friction is the point? And where does the saved time go?

PART 5 · HANDS UP

Which story fits your last month with AI?

Count hands, then click the matching button. Shift-click removes one.

Gym: it made me do the reps	Forklift: it lifted what I should have	Commute: it took the dull parts	Treadmill: saved time, filled it with more	Barely used it
0	0	0	0	0

Reset

PART 5 · WHERE SHOULD AI GO?

Keep it human, add friction, or hand it off?

Keep it human | Use it, with friction | Hand it off

Feedback on a student's draft Click to sort	Formatting a reference list Click to sort	The first draft of your own argument Click to sort	A recommendation letter Click to sort
Reading a manuscript you were asked to review Click to sort	Transcribing a research interview Click to sort	Practice quiz questions for your class Click to sort	Replying to a hard email from a student Click to sort

There's no answer key. The line moves with the task and the person, which is why we draw it on purpose.

Reset cards

PART 5 · STORIES THAT LOOK AHEAD

It's 2031, and AI went well here. How?

DRAFT EXAMPLES: BERT TO PICK OR REPLACE

Asks of us now: think first, ask second, and make the call yourself.

Asks of us now: decide where saved time goes before it's saved.

Asks of us now: set it up to question, not to answer.

Asks of us now: show up when we decide what it's for.

A story worth telling says who decides, what we keep doing ourselves, and where the saved time goes.

PART 5 · TALK AT YOUR TABLE

Three questions for your table

WHO DECIDES?

A story you hear

Pick a story about AI you hear in your unit. Who acts in it? What does it leave you to decide?

WHERE IT GOES

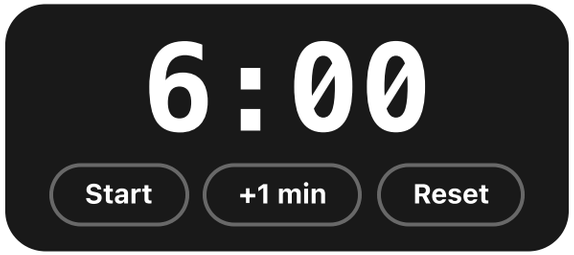
Keep, add friction, hand off

Name one task in your work for each. Where would you add a plate on purpose?

LOOKING AHEAD

Tell it from 2031

AI went well here. In two sentences, what did we choose?



PART 5 · SHARE OUT

What did your table choose?

OUR STORY FROM 2031	WE'D KEEP IT HUMAN	A FRICTION WE'LL CHOOSE

Click a cell and type. Notes stay in this browser only. Clear board

TO TAKE WITH YOU

Choosing the story is a judgment call

Stories fill gaps

For people and for models, a story settles what the facts leave open.

Many true stories, some work

You can’t tell which by reading. You try it and check it against what you know.

Tell stories that leave you choices

Ones that say who decides, which frictions we keep, and where the saved time goes.

KEEP GOING

Thank you

Narrate
Keep writing stories. Code **AISYMP2026**, valid through November 30, 2026.

NARC puzzles
About 320 puzzles to solve, and a page to make your own.

MindRouter
The university's own AI service. Sign in with your university account.

These slides and a plain-text companion: bertybaums.github.io/narratives-workshop · Questions: bbaum@uidaho.edu